

Building a Japanese Tourism Ephemera Archive: Case Studies, Metadata Design, and Prototype Development

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Abstract

This paper presents ongoing work to build a comprehensive archive of Japanese tourism ephemera. Despite their importance as primary sources for a wide range of research fields in understanding historical and contemporary society, ephemera materials, including brochures, leaflets, and pamphlets, are rarely systematically collected and preserved. Through case studies of ephemera collections, we identified key challenges in archiving ephemera: physical preservation methods, metadata standardization, and sustainable collection practices. Based on these findings, we designed a metadata schema incorporating both standard and ephemera-specific elements, and developed tool prototypes to support metadata creation workflows. We adopted an iterative approach, including collaboration with a local public library, in order to conduct real-world testing and progressive development of the ephemera archive. Our work provides practical insights for designing archival systems while balancing ideal practices and practical constraints, contributing to the preservation of cultural materials and supporting research in various fields.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → **Digital libraries and archives; Document metadata**; *Arts and humanities; Law, social and behavioral sciences.*

Keywords

Digital archives, metadata, cultural heritage, tourism ephemera, preservation

ACM Reference Format:

Xinru Zhu, Ayumi Katsuki, Kashin Sugishita, Ning Yang, and Tomokazu Takada. 2025. Building a Japanese Tourism Ephemera Archive: Case Studies, Metadata Design, and Prototype Development. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '25)*, April 26–May 01, 2025, Yokohama, Japan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 8 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3719879>

1 Introduction

Ephemera refers to minor printed materials not intended to survive beyond their immediate purpose [11, 12]. Tourism brochures, as a form of ephemera, serve functions beyond their direct informational and promotional purposes. As Katsuki and Okuyama [5, 6] demonstrated through their analysis of linguistic expressions in Japanese tourism brochures, these materials function to structure and present local values to external audiences. Molina and Esteban [7] showed how tourism brochures operate as crucial tools for image construction and destination marketing, while Scarles [13] analyzed their role in mediating landscape representation and cultural narratives.

The significance of ephemera extends beyond tourism studies. Twyman [15] highlighted their importance as records of social and cultural change, while Young [16] discussed their value as evidence of everyday life and commercial practices. These materials can serve as primary sources for a variety of research fields, including but not limited to tourism studies, urban planning, graphic design history, advertising history, architectural history, and cultural representation studies.

Despite their scholarly value, the characteristics of ephemeral materials—their transient nature, diverse content, varied use cases, and irregular formats—pose challenges for systematic collection and preservation by libraries and other institutions [11]. Japanese tourism brochures are no exception. In Japan, no institution systematically collects tourism brochures for long-term preservation. While Saga City Library maintains a collection of tourism brochures, this is intended for public information rather than preservation¹. This situation, stemming from both the nature of ephemera and various institutional resource constraints, results in the loss of crucial

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CHI EA '25, Yokohama, Japan

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1395-8/25/04
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3719879>

¹As noted in Section 2, we initiated a partnership with Saga City Library to collect and preserve the discarded items.

primary sources for understanding historical and contemporary socio-cultural conditions.

In response to this situation, our research aims to (1) establish a comprehensive framework for systematically collecting and preserving Japanese tourism ephemera, (2) design a metadata schema that balances standardization with the unique characteristics of ephemera, (3) develop a sustainable archiving workflow that can operate with limited resources, and (4) propose effective methods for providing access to these materials for users across multiple disciplines.

Our work builds upon and extends previous research on ephemera preservation and digital archiving. While Rickards [12] established foundational approaches to ephemera collection, and Twyman [15] discussed their historical significance, fewer studies have addressed the specific challenges of tourism ephemera. In the digital archiving domain, existing standards like those described by Zeng and Qin [17] provide general frameworks, but require adaptation for specialized collections. These gaps in the related work will also be addressed in our research.

This paper reports on our progress in developing this ephemera archive. We begin by explaining our research methodology, followed by sections detailing our survey of existing cases, metadata schema design, and prototype development. Finally, we summarize our current work and discuss future prospects.

2 Methodology

As noted in Section 1, there is no comprehensive archive of tourism ephemera exists in Japan. Few archives worldwide systematically collect tourism ephemera, and to our knowledge, none actively collect contemporary materials. Therefore, there are no directly applicable precedents for our work, and the requirements for tourism ephemera archives remain unclear.

Consequently, we adopted an iterative approach for this research. As shown in Figure 1, we cycle through survey, implementation, and evaluation phases to progressively clarify requirements for tourism ephemera archives, develop physical collections and digital archives, and verify their utility. While each phase comprises multiple tasks, those marked with asterisks in Figure 1 have been completed as a first step and are detailed in this paper.

Our survey phase consisted of case studies and literature reviews. For the case studies, we visited institutions that hold ephemera collections in Japan and the United States and interviewed librarians to gain practical insights into collection and preservation practices. The literature review examined prior research and cases on ephemera collection and preservation, as well as metadata standards, guidelines, and existing schemas.

In the implementation phase, we designed a metadata schema and developed prototype tools for metadata creation and digital archiving. We initiated preliminary material collection by gathering 247 tourism brochures from across Japan at the Tokyo Metropolitan Government Building’s Japanese Prefectural Tourism Promotion Corner. Additionally, we established a collaborative partnership with Saga City Library to develop a framework in which the library will donate discarded tourism brochures to our project every year, enabling continuous collection of tourism ephemera.

The results of survey and implementation phases will be detailed in subsequent sections.

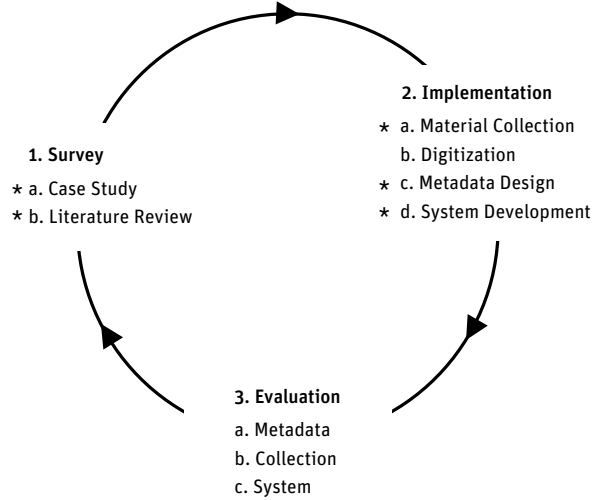


Figure 1: The framework of our iterative research approach

3 Case studies

We selected five ephemera collections at four institutions for case studies: the tourism brochure collection at Saga City Library in Japan, Avery’s Architectural Ephemera Collections at Columbia University [2], Baker Library’s Advertising Ephemera Collection at Harvard University [3], and Japanese Film Ephemera Collection and Japanese LGBTQ Ephemera Collection at Yale University [8].

These cases were selected for their distinctive characteristics: Saga City Library is Japan’s only systematic collector of tourism brochures; Yale University maintains Japanese-language ephemera collections; and Columbia and Harvard Universities have systematically collected, preserved, and digitized large-scale ephemera collections. The lead authors conducted site visits to Saga City Library in February 2023 and to the institutions in the United States in July 2023.

Our investigation examined four key aspects: collection methods, preservation practices, digitization approaches, and metadata design. We paid particular attention to preservation techniques and metadata schemas that address ephemera’s distinct physical characteristics, as well as their use cases by the library users. Table 1 shows basic information, and Tables 2 and 3 summarize key findings from each case.

The results show that while “[e]phemera comes in formats and dimensions that can be unwieldy and extend beyond the normal range of library materials, from postage stamps to posters, and present difficulties in housing, physical organization, and access” [11], institutions are adopting flexible approaches based on material characteristics and expected use cases.

The findings also highlight the importance of balancing ideal practices with feasible implementation. For instance: (1) long-term

Table 1: Basic information of ephemera collections

Case	Item types	Collection period	State	Extent
Saga City Library	Tourism brochures	1996–present	Ongoing (not for preservation)	Not documented
Avery’s Architectural Ephemera Collections	Trade catalogs, viewbooks, postcards, letterheads, real estate brochures, novelties	19th–20th century	Completed	More than 31,600 items
Baker Library’s Advertising Ephemera Collection	Trade cards, ship cards, business cards, labels, posters	19th–20th century	Completed	45 boxes and 3 map case drawers
Japanese Film Ephemera Collection	Handbills, press kits, theater pamphlets, newsletters, catalogs	1970s–present	Ongoing	16 boxes
Japanese LGBTQ Ephemera Collection	Fliers, newsletters, brochures, educational materials	1993–present	Ongoing	4 boxes

Table 2: Key findings of collection and preservation practices

Case	Collection	Preservation	Digitization	Metadata	Use cases
Saga City Library	The country is divided into 5 regions. Materials from one region are collected every 5 years from local governments.	Old materials are discarded when new ones arrive. Only local materials are stored long-term.	No digitization is performed.	Catalog records are created only for materials that qualify as books.	Use cases are not tracked.
Avery’s Architectural Ephemera Collections	Acquired through donations and purchases. Closed to new acquisitions.	Items are stored in acid-free file folders and boxes. Related items are grouped together in the same file. Custom-made containers for irregularly shaped items such as souvenirs.	Specialist teams perform comprehensive digitization. Digitization captures physical characteristics (e.g., brochures are digitized in both folded and unfolded states).	Each item has detailed metadata entry. Metadata schema adapts institutional standards and modified to suit items (e.g., a field to record the address of the building featured in the item). Single staff maintains consistency of metadata entries.	Primarily used by architecture students and researchers for coursework and research.

preservation and digitization of large collections is feasible primarily for well-resourced university libraries, (2) consistent metadata creation is challenging for ongoing collections, as new materials may require schema modifications, (3) following institutional standards is essential for long-term sustainability, (4) different materials

have varying copyright and privacy constraints affecting public access, (5) setting overly ambitious goals and standards risks compromising collection sustainability.

These findings validated our iterative approach, suggesting the value of progressively expanding collections while refining the

Table 3: Key findings of collection and preservation practices (continued)

Case	Collection	Preservation	Digitization	Metadata	Use cases
Baker Library's Advertising Ephemera Collection	Acquired through donations and purchases.	Items are stored in acid-free file folders and boxes.	Over 1,000 trade cards are digitized.	Metadata schema adapts institutional standards and modified to suit items.	Primarily used by students and researchers for economic history and art research.
	Selective acquisitions from dealers and donors are accepted.	Conservation work is performed on damaged materials.	Specialist teams perform digitization. Digitization captures physical characteristics (e.g., open/closed conditions, individual pages).	Content elements (e.g., products, industries, imagery) and physical characteristics (e.g., die-cuts, folds, paper types) are captured in detail, but too detailed metadata schema proved unsustainable for consistent metadata entry across staff members. The scope of metadata is carefully considered to balance comprehensiveness and maintainability.	
Yale University's Japanese Ephemera Collections	Materials are being collected through researcher networks.	Materials are stored in acid-free file folders and boxes.	No digitization due to copyright and privacy considerations.	No metadata entry for each item.	Used for academic research.
		Uses series-based organization. Some materials are broadly organized (e.g., by film director) due to limited Japanese-speaking staff.		Finding aids are created at collection level. Finding aids and series organization are developed in consultation with university archivists. Collection development goals (e.g., metadata and access scopes) are carefully set to ensure long-term sustainability.	Specific uses are not tracked.

metadata schema and digital archive capabilities based on practical constraints.

4 Metadata design

Based on the results of the case studies, we designed a metadata schema informed by existing metadata standards [17], guidelines [10], established metadata models such as Functional Requirements for Bibliographic Records (FRBR), IFLA Library Reference Model (IFLA

LRM), and CIDOC Conceptual Reference Model (CIDOC CRM), and specific schemas such as Metadata Object Description Schema (MODS), National Diet Library Dublin Core Metadata Description (DC-NDL) [9], the Structured Model for Museum Object Information [14], and the Media Arts Database Schema [1]. In line with the National Diet Library's *Metadata Distribution Guidelines* [10], we established three core principles to guide the development of the metadata schema—usability, interoperability, and consistency and

uniformity. In the context of this research, these principles can be elaborated as follows:

- Usability: to be applied effectively by researchers and archivists working with diverse types of ephemera
 - Drawing from existing ephemera archives
 - Creating mechanisms for the flexible addition of metadata fields to accommodate specific and evolving needs
- Interoperability: to facilitate seamless integration with existing metadata formats and systems
 - Aligning with internationally recognized standards
- Consistency and uniformity: to ensure consistency across collections, time periods, and institutions
 - Aligning with national guidelines for basic elements
 - Employing controlled vocabularies

Based on these principles, the development of the preliminary metadata schema followed a structured and iterative process. We began by listing metadata elements outlined in the *Metadata Distribution Guidelines* [10], which provided a baseline of required elements. Building on this foundation, additional elements were derived from Avery’s Architectural Ephemera Collection to address the specific needs of ephemera. We further added custom fields that were necessary for tourism ephemera and expected use cases by researchers in our project. Finally, the compiled elements were reviewed and refined to ensure clarity and consistency.

This process resulted in a 38-element metadata schema which is provided in Appendix A. This metadata schema is not finalized and will be revised and refined as the project progresses.

5 Prototype development

Based on the designed metadata schema, we developed two web-based tool prototypes for the tourism ephemera archive: a metadata creation tool and a digital archive system.

To address the human resource constraints identified and metadata completeness challenges identified in our case studies, the metadata creation tool incorporated several design features: (1) 24-hour preservation feature for in-progress entries, ensuring that users can resume their work without data loss in the event of interruptions, (2) input examples and detailed field descriptions, providing clear guidance on users unfamiliar with metadata standards and specific features of ephemera materials, (3) minimal required fields with only the resource title designated as mandatory, enabling users with varying levels of expertise to contribute thus maintaining the sustainability of the archive.

We tested these tools by entering basic metadata for 247 collected items described in Section 2. This testing process allowed us to verify the practicality and usability of both the metadata schema and the metadata creation tool preliminarily without formal metrics. We found that the schema adequately captured essential characteristics of most materials, including complex folding patterns, cross-boundary geographic information, and descriptive text information. However, several challenges emerged: metadata creation required 5–10 minutes per item even for basic entry, which may be problematic for large-scale collections, and certain fields proved difficult for users to complete consistently either because of their subjectivity or the specialized knowledge they require. These findings indicate the necessity to refine field definitions, develop

controlled vocabularies, and optimize the interface in the future iterations. We also intend to conduct formal evaluations as future work.

Figure 3 illustrates the metadata creation workflow, which outlines the step-by-step process for entering metadata of a tourism brochure. Figure 2 presents the interface of the digital archive system².

6 Discussion and future work

This paper has reported on the progress toward building a comprehensive archive of Japanese tourism ephemera. We have (1) identified practical challenges in archiving ephemera through case studies, (2) designed a preliminary metadata schema for tourism ephemera, and (3) developed prototypes of a metadata creation tool and a digital archive system.

From a practical perspective, our work demonstrates the inherent tension between ideal archival practices and operational feasibility. While comprehensive metadata is desirable, our case studies revealed that overly detailed schemas can become unsustainable; similarly, while full digitization is ideal, resource constraints and copyright considerations often limit its possibility. These findings suggest that pragmatic compromises in archival design are not merely concessions to limitations but essential features of sustainable cultural heritage preservation.

Theoretically, our work contributes to understanding ephemera as boundary objects that bridge multiple domains. The multifaceted nature of ephemera materials necessitates a metadata schema that accommodates diverse use cases while maintaining practical usability.

At the intersection of human-computer interaction and cultural heritage, our tool design balances precision with flexibility. Features like 24-hour data preservation and embedded field guidance demonstrate how digital tools can address the realities of archival work performed by users with varying expertise levels.

Two notable limitations of the current research should be acknowledged. First, we have not yet conducted a comprehensive comparison between our proposed archive and other existing archives, which will provide insight into the usability of the proposed archive and areas for improvement. Second, while the proposed schema includes fields for rights management, we have not investigated and implemented protocols for handling copyright, privacy, and access restrictions, which is important for contemporary materials that may contain sensitive information or remain under active copyright protection. These limitations will be addressed in our future work.

In addition, significant challenges remain for (1) developing mechanisms for the flexible addition of metadata fields to accommodate new materials and use cases, (2) enhancing a sustainable operational framework that incorporates both physical and digital workflows, (3) optimizing system design for different user groups, and (4) developing an evaluation methodology to measure project success.

Furthermore, future work ideas include (1) developing a participatory framework that engages community contributors in the

²These figures show the Japanese-language interface. We plan to develop multilingual support to make the tools and systems accessible to international researchers.

タイトル	場所	キーワード	データ登録日
阿蘇	(熊本県)		2025年01月23日
ココロ、オドル、天草市!	(熊本県)		2025年01月23日
天草の結津集落	(熊本県)		2025年01月23日
くまもとでいたい50のこと	(熊本県)		2025年01月23日
くまもと旅マップ	(熊本県)		2025年01月23日
旅 伊万里	(佐賀県)		2025年01月23日
武雄	(佐賀県)		2025年01月23日
UWABA BOOK	(佐賀県)		2025年01月23日
有田	(佐賀県)		2025年01月23日
鹿島	(佐賀県)		2025年01月23日

a. List view



b. Item view

Figure 2: The interface of the digital archive system prototype

collection process, (2) implementing multi-modal representation techniques such as 3D models, videos, and animations to better capture physical characteristics of ephemera, (3) investigating automated approaches for metadata extraction, integrating machine learning and computer vision techniques.

For the CHI community, this work emphasizes the value of the iterative process in system design. Successful cultural heritage systems should accommodate not only information organization principles but also social, institutional, and material realities in which preservation occurs. Through continued iteration and community input, we aim to develop robust solutions for preserving these valuable but ephemeral cultural materials.

Acknowledgments

This research was supported by National Institute for Japanese Language and Linguistics Collaborative Research Projects (Project No. 29320). We would like to express our gratitude to the librarians and staff at Saga City Library, Avery Architectural and Fine Arts Library, Harvard Business School Baker Library, and Yale University Library for their generous support and cooperation during our case studies.

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A Metadata schema

b. Enter prefectures and municipalities

郵便番号

郵便番号は市区町村の郵便局に所属する地域を特定するために用いられる数字のコードです。

郵便番号検索

山梨県

市町村別

南都賀村*	〒 〒
富士吉田市	〒 ↓
南都賀村*	↑ 〒
赤坂町	〒 ↓
南都賀村*	↑ 〒
西条町	〒 ↓
南都賀村*	↑ 〒
石狩村	〒 ↓
南都賀村*	↑ 〒
山中湖村	〒 ↓

d. Enter format, size, material type, folding methods, etc.


電通エディタマシナリールガイド
三

印刷形式

紙

印刷形式を選択してください。

その他

PDFを印刷してください。

紙のサイズ

A4 (mm)

紙のサイズを選択してください。

高さ (mm)

185

紙の高さを選択してください。

幅 (mm)

262

紙の幅を選択してください。

紙の種類

シートカット

紙の種類を選択してください。

印刷のオプション

印刷のオプションを選択してください。印刷のオプションを選択してください。

印刷のオプション

印刷のオプションを選択してください。印刷のオプションを選択してください。

f. Enter other versions and formats (digital ones)

The screenshot shows the "新規ファイルの作成" (Create New File) dialog box in Visual Studio Code. The title bar at the top reads "新設したファイルを開く | アーカイブ". The main area contains a text input field with "A1.txt" entered. To the right of the input are icons for file operations: a plus sign in a square, a document icon, and a minus sign in a square. Below the input field is a blue button labeled "作成" (Create). Underneath the button is a section titled "詳細" (Details), which includes a label "名前: A1.txt" and a text area containing the file path: "C:\Users\kai\Desktop\VSCode\workspace\test\A1.txt". Below this is another section titled "拡張子と形式 (ディレクトリ構造を保持)" (Extension and Format (Preserve Directory Structure)), followed by an empty text input field. Then there's a section titled "属性 (ディレクトリ構造を保持)" (Attributes (Preserve Directory Structure)). At the bottom, there's a URL field containing "https://www.dia.ncl.go.jp/info/ndip/pj/pd/1297435/www.fujisan-3776.jp/info-ii" and a "フォルダ名" (Folder Name) field containing "epf_20240228_121934_39thgrou". At the very bottom, a note states: "このファイルは既に存在している文字列が読み取られ、既存のディレクトリファイルも含まれる可能性があります。" (This file may already exist and contain character strings, and existing directory files may also be included.)

Figure 3: An example of the metadata creation workflow with the brochure titled *Fujisan Tour of World Heritage Site* [4]

Table 4: Metadata schema for tourism ephemera archive

Group	Field	Element	Description
Title	Title	dcterms:title	Main title of the resource
	Alternative title	dcterms:alternative	Alternative title (e.g., English translation)
Creator	Author/Creator	dcterms:creator	Creator or author of the resource
	Contributor	dc:contributor	Contributors to the resource
Publication	Publisher	dcterms:publisher	Publisher of the resource
	Place of publication	dcndl:location	Place of publication
	Metadata provider	dcterms:source	Metadata provider
	Holding institution	dcndl:holdingAgent	Holding institution
Dates	Date of acquisition	dcterms:date	Date of acquisition
	Date of digitization	dcndl:dateDigitized	Date of digitization
	Date of publication	dcterms:issued	Date of publication
Subject	Subject/classification	dc:subject	Subject headings (using NDLSH)
	Spatial coverage	dcterms:spatial	Geographic coverage (prefecture and municipality)
	Temporal coverage	dcterms:temporal	Temporal coverage
Content	Abstract	dcterms:abstract	Abstract or summary
	Notes	dcterms:description	Notes
Language	Language	dcterms:language	Resource language
	Language of metadata	dcterms:language	Metadata language
Format	Material type	dc:materialType	Resource type (using NDL Type vocabulary)
	Format	dcterms:format	MIME type (for digital resources)
	Size	dcterms:extent	Dimensions (folded size: width × height in mm)
	File size	dcterms:extent	File size (for digital resources)
	Pages	dcterms:extent	Number of pages
	Binding	dcterms:description	Binding method (controlled vocabulary needed)
	Paper size	dcterms:description	Paper size (standard format if applicable)
	Typeface	dcterms:description	Typeface information
Rights	License	dc:license	License information
	Access rights	dcterms:accessRights	Access restrictions
	Copyright	dcterms:rights	Copyright information
	Copyright holder	dcterms:rightsHolder	Copyright holder
Relations	Collection name	dcterms:isPartOf	Collection name
	Box number	dcterms:identifier	Box number
	Folder number	dcterms:identifier	Folder number
	Different edition	dcterms:hasVersion	Alternative versions (e.g., archived URL)
	Different format	dcterms:hasFormat	Format variations
Content Access	IIIF Manifest	rdf:type	IIIF manifest URI
	Thumbnail	foaf:thumbnail	Thumbnail image
	Primary resource	owl:sameAs	Primary resource URL (for digital resources)